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The Konbaung Dynasty (1752–1885)

THE RISE OF THE ALAÙNGPAYÀ AND THE REUNIFICATION OF BURMA

The Konbaung dynasty succeeded the Restored Toungoo dynasty when King Alaùngpayà (r. ca. 1752–1760) was crowned king in the northern township of Shwebo in 1752. U Aung Zeiya of Moksobo (who is also known as Alaùngpayà) was a village chief when the Mon kingdom of Pegu invaded Ava in 1752. Utilizing his considerable leadership skills Alaùngpayà was able to rally other local village chiefs to defeat the invading Mon forces. Following successive victories against the Mon, Alaùngpayà was enthroned as king by his fellow village chiefs in 1752, thus founding the Konbaung dynasty (heaven's platform), the third and last Burman empire. The following year he recaptured Ava. In 1754, Alaùngpayà took advantage of the Burman revolt against the Mon at Prome to launch a military expedition against the Mon. In early 1755, the fall of Prome opened the way to the Ayeyarwaddy delta, where his army took a number of Mon cities. The following year he began a series of campaigns designed at uniting the Burmans. He captured Syriam, thus depriving Pegu of its source of foreign arms and reinforcements. In May 1757, he forced the capitulation of Pegu despite the fact that the Mon were aided by French mercenaries. The mutinous Mon king Binnya Dala was captured and publicly executed during a religious festival at the Shwedagon pagoda in Rangoon. In the wake of the defeat to the Burman many Mon chose to emigrate to neighboring Ayutthaya rather than to assimilate. Following the capitulation of the Peguan court, Alaùngpayà sought to cut disassociate himself and his dynasty with the former Mon seat of power at Pegu by establishing a new chief port city in Lower Burma at the village of Dagon, which he renamed Rangoon.